



Sant'Anna
Scuola Universitaria Superiore Pisa

Security Assistance in Fragile Contexts

Master in International Security Studies (MISS)

Prof. Kevin Koehler, PhD

AY 2026/2027

Course Information

Term: AY 2026/2027, Semester I

Credits: 6 CFU

Schedule: See course calendar

Dates: 22/09/2026 to 14/12/2026

Instructor Information

Name: Prof. Kevin Koehler, PhD

Email: kevin.koehler@santannapisa.it

Office Hours: By appointment

Contents

International actors have long attempted to project power by supporting armed actors in other places, particularly in contexts of conflict and instability. These practices, subsumed under the heading of **security assistance**, are at the center of this course. Why do states provide security assistance? Is security assistance an approach to (post-conflict) stabilization, a form of war making by proxy, or a postcolonial ordering device (or all of the above)? Why does security assistance frequently fail to meet its declared objectives?

We begin by problematizing the concept itself, starting from the notion of the state outside the world of Western Educated Industrialized Rich Democracies (WEIRD). We then discuss a range of theoretical perspectives on security assistance itself, including principal-agent models, proxy war arguments, and postcolonial approaches.

Equipped with a conceptual toolkit, we move on to examine a variety of security assistance strategies from the perspective of **providers**. We look at the (evolving) security assistance strategies of the United States, the European Union and its member states, and of NATO, but also focus on non-Western providers such as Russia, Iran, and the Arab Gulf states. In the last part, finally, we discuss specific **cases** of security assistance aiming at understanding how security assistance policies interact with conflict and instability, but also with larger strategic interests.

As part of the course, we will have a series of interventions by outside experts, including both academics and security assistance practitioners.

Bibliography

All assigned readings are listed below in the course calendar and can be accessed [here](#).

Course objectives and learning outcomes

By the end of the course, students will be able to:

- Understand the conceptual and historical background of security assistance
- Analyze the strategies of key provider states and organizations
- Evaluate case studies critically
- Apply theoretical perspectives to real-world contexts

Teaching methods and activities

- Lectures
- Class discussions
- Group work

Assessment

The assessment will be based on **three elements** which build on each other. All participants are expected to develop a **case study** of security assistance by a specific provider or in a specific context, in the form of a short paper (maximum **3,000 words**). The paper will be circulated to the group **at least 3 days** before the relevant class session, and all other participants are expected to read it.

During the corresponding session, the **authors will present** their paper (maximum **15 minutes**).



The third element is a **final project**, which can (but does not necessarily have to) build on the case study. This final product should be a **full academic paper** (maximum **5,000 words**), including:

- a research question derived from the (theoretical) literature,
- a research design explaining how the question will be answered,
- an empirical analysis section,
- and conclusions.

The final project is due on **TBA**.

The **final grade** will be composed as follows:

- **Case study:** 30%
- **Presentation:** 20%
- **Final project:** 50%

Use of generative AI

Generative AI tools may be used for language editing, for clarifying concepts, and for exploring the literature. They may not be used to generate the substance of your written work: the argument, the analysis, and the interpretation of evidence must be your own.

Two rules follow from this. First, you remain fully responsible for everything you submit, including any factual claim or citation produced with AI assistance. Fabricated references are treated as any other citation error. Second, any substantive use of AI tools must be disclosed in a short note at the end of the paper, specifying which tool was used and for what purpose.

If in doubt about whether a particular use is acceptable, ask before rather than after submitting.



Course calendar

1. Introduction to the Course

Tuesday, 22 September 2026, 11:00–13:00

- Rolandsen, Øystein H., Michael Dwyer, and William Reno. 2021. “Security Force Assistance to Fragile States: A Framework of Analysis.” *Journal of Intervention and Statebuilding* 15 (5): 563–579. <https://doi.org/10.1080/17502977.2021.1988224>
 - Berg, Louis-Alexandre. 2025. “US Security Force Assistance and Civil-Military Relations.” *Security Studies* 34 (4): 624–657. <https://doi.org/10.1080/09636412.2025.2545859>
-

Part 1: Concepts

2. States and Control

Thursday, 1 October 2026, 14:00–16:00

- Herbst, Jeffrey. 2000. *States and Power in Africa: Comparative Lessons in Authority and Control*. Princeton: Princeton University Press. Part 1.
- Migdal, Joel S. 2001. *State in Society: Studying How States and Societies Transform and Constitute One Another*. Cambridge: Cambridge University Press. Chapter 1.
- Benson, Matthew Sterling. 2025. “Predatory Peace: Fiscal Fragmentation and Coercive Statebuilding in South Sudan and Beyond.” *Journal of Intervention and Statebuilding*, published online 25 December 2025, 1–22. <https://doi.org/10.1080/17502977.2025.2576462>

3. States and Security

Wednesday, 7 October 2026, 14:00–16:00

- Ayooob, Mohammed. 1995. *The Third World Security Predicament*. Boulder: Lynne Rienner. Chapters 1 and 2.
- Krieg, Andreas. 2022. “Regime Security.” In *Contemporary Security Studies*, edited by Alan Collins, 218–232. Oxford: Oxford University Press.
- Dodge, Toby. 2025. “Iraq, Regime Change, and the Reconstruction of the Security Field: The Rebirth of Impunity in a Disaggregated State.” *Middle East Critique*, published online 21 September 2025. <https://doi.org/10.1080/19436149.2025.2546164>



4. State Fragility

Wednesday, 14 October 2026, 14:00–16:00

- Asylbek kyzy, Gulzhan, Gary Milante, Zina Nimeh, and Kaj Thomsson. 2025. “Lost in Aggregation: Navigating Noise and Signals in Measuring State Fragility.” *Development Policy Review* 43 (6): e70041. <https://doi.org/10.1111/dpr.70041>
 - Woodward, Susan. 2017. *The Ideology of Failed States: Why Intervention Fails*. Cambridge: Cambridge University Press. Introduction and Chapter 1.
-

Part 2: Theoretical Approaches

5. Principal-Agent Relations

Friday, 23 October 2026, 14:00–16:00

- Biddle, Stephen, Julia Macdonald, and Ryan Baker. 2017. “Small Footprint, Small Payoff: The Military Effectiveness of Security Force Assistance.” *Journal of Strategic Studies* 41 (1–2): 89–142. <https://doi.org/10.1080/01402390.2017.1307745>
- Metz, Rachel, and Renanah Joyce. 2025. “Putting the Civilian Back in Civil–Military Relations: How Civilian Leaders Condition the Effects of Security Assistance.” *International Studies Quarterly* 69 (1): sqaf002. <https://doi.org/10.1093/isq/sqaf002>

6. Proxy War

Friday, 30 October 2026, 14:00–16:00

- Rauta, Vladimir. 2020. “Framers, Founders, and Reformers: Three Generations of Proxy War Research.” *Contemporary Security Policy* 42 (1): 113–134. <https://doi.org/10.1080/13523260.2020.1800240>
- Stark, Alexandra. 2023. “The Historical Evolution of Proxy Wars” In *Routledge Handbook of Proxy Wars*, edited by Assaf Moghadam, Vladimir Rauta, and Michel Wyss, 153–162. London: Routledge.
- Karlén, Niklas, and Vladimir Rauta. 2026. “Strings Attached: How Foreign States Control Non-State Armed Groups.” *Journal of Strategic Studies*, published online 24 April 2026, 1–31. <https://doi.org/10.1080/01402390.2026.2660233>



7. Postcolonial Approaches

Monday, 2 November 2026, 11:00–13:00

- Tholens, Simone, and Chiara Ruffa. 2023. “The Elephant in the Med: Postcoloniality and European Security Assistance Practices.” *Mediterranean Politics* 29 (4): 573–596. <https://doi.org/10.1080/13629395.2023.2183662>
 - Tholens, Simone, and Al-Jabassini, Aymenn. 2023. “(Re)ordering the Mediterranean: The Evolution of Security Assistance as an International Practice.” *Mediterranean Politics* 29 (4): 433–453. <https://doi.org/10.1080/13629395.2023.2183658>
 - Tholens, Simone, and Ada Sophia Hahn. 2025. “Strategic Intimacy in International Security: The Relational Politics of Security Assistance.” *Cooperation and Conflict*, published online 16 October 2025. <https://doi.org/10.1177/00108367251380671>
-

Part 3: Providers

8. U.S. Security Assistance

Monday, 9 November 2026, 11:00–13:00

Group: TBA (paper due date **6 November 2026**)

- Joyce, Renanah Miles, Theodore McLauchlin, and Lee Seymour. 2024. “Train the World: Examining the Logics of US Foreign Military Training.” *International Studies Quarterly* 68 (2): sqae044. <https://doi.org/10.1093/isq/sqae044>
- Matissek, Jahara. 2018. “The Crisis of American Military Assistance: Strategic Dithering and Fabergé Egg Armies.” *Defense & Security Analysis* 34 (3): 267–90. <https://doi.org/10.1080/14751798.2018.1500757>
- Larsdotter, Kersti. 2026. “Coercion by Military Assistance: A Two-Level Strategy.” *Journal of Strategic Studies*, published online 31 March 2026. <https://doi.org/10.1080/01402390.2026.2650788>
- Chindea, Irina A., Elina Treyger, Tahina Montoya, and Kiki Hunegs. 2026. *Force Multipliers in the Americas: Harnessing Security Force Assistance to Bolster Homeland Defense and U.S. Strategic Objectives in Latin America*. Santa Monica, CA: RAND Corporation, RR-A3928-1.



9. Russian Security Assistance

Tuesday, 10 November 2026, 14:00–16:00

Group: TBA (paper due date **6 November 2026**)

- Manfredi Firmian, Federico. 2024. “Russia’s State Capture Strategy in Africa, from Wagner to the Africa Corps.” *Small Wars & Insurgencies*, December, 1–30. <https://doi.org/10.1080/09592318.2024.2432832>
- Spearin, Christopher. 2024. “Russia’s Wagner Group/Africa Corps: An Authoritarian Conflict Management Examination.” *Conflict, Security & Development* 24 (5): 479–99. <https://doi.org/10.1080/14678802.2024.2415659>
- Spearin, Christopher. 2025. “Russia’s Wagner Group and the Sustainment of Authoritarianism in Africa: Implications for China at Home and Abroad.” *Contemporary Security Policy* 46 (3): 497–521. <https://doi.org/10.1080/13523260.2025.2474763>

10. NATO Security Assistance

Monday, 16 November 2026, 11:00–13:00

Group: TBA (paper due date **13 November 2026**)

- Koehler, Kevin. 2023. “The Politics of Security Assistance by “European NATO”“, in *Security Assistance in the Middle East*, edited by Hicham Alaoui and Robert Springborg, 149-170. Boulder, USA: Lynne Rienner Publishers, pp. 149–170. <https://doi.org/10.1515/9781955055994-009>
- Desmaele, Linde. 2024. “Burden Sharing for What? NATO Implications of Three US Visions.” *The Washington Quarterly* 47 (4): 27–43. <https://doi.org/10.1080/0163660X.2024.2432808>

11. European (Union) Security Assistance

Tuesday, 17 November 2026, 14:00–16:00

Group: TBA (paper due date **13 November 2026**)

- Gaub, Florence and Walsh, Alex. “EU and Member States’ Security Assistance: Complementary or Contradictory?” In *Security Assistance in the Middle East*, 133-148. <https://doi.org/10.1515/9781955055994-008>
- Håkansson, Calle. 2023. “The Ukraine War and the Emergence of the European Commission as a Geopolitical Actor.” *Journal of European Integration* 46 (1): 25–45. <https://doi.org/10.1080/07036337.2023.2239998>



- Romanyshyn, Iulian, and Julian Bergmann. 2025. "Preference Convergence, Functional Pressure and Supranational Entrepreneurship: Explaining the Launch and Design of the EU's Military Assistance Mission to Ukraine." *European Security* 35 (1): 148–168. <https://doi.org/10.1080/09662839.2025.2506515>
- Mustasilta, Katariina, and Tyyne Karjalainen. 2025. "European Strategic Cultures in Flux? Case Study on the European Peace Facility." *European Journal of International Security*, published online 23 October 2025, 1–23. <https://doi.org/10.1017/eis.2025.10022>

12. Iranian Security Assistance

Monday, 23 November 2026, 11:00–13:00

Group: TBA (paper due date **20 November 2026**)

- Divsallar, Abdolrasool, and Hamidreza Azizi. 2023. "Towards a Non-Western Model of Security Assistance: How Iran Assists Militaries." *Mediterranean Politics* 29 (4): 550–72. <https://doi.org/10.1080/13629395.2023.2183661>
- Jahanbani, Nakissa, and Suzanne Weedon Levy. 2023. "Iran's Proxy War Strategy." In *Routledge Handbook of Proxy Wars*, 340–353. <https://doi.org/10.4324/9781003174066-31>
- Dadparvar, Shabnam, and Amin Parto. 2025. "Iran and Post-Assad Syria: Strategic Dilemmas and Constraints." *Journal of Balkan and Near Eastern Studies*, published online 11 September 2025. <https://doi.org/10.1080/19448953.2025.2557168>
- Limbu, Ariel Limanya, and Ronen A. Cohen. 2026. "Iran's Forward Defense in Sub-Saharan Africa." *Middle East Policy* 33 (2): 57–71. <https://doi.org/10.1111/mepo.70069>

13. Arab Gulf States' Security Assistance

Tuesday, 24 November 2026, 11:00–13:00

Group: TBA (paper due date **20 November 2026**)

- Hedges, Matthew. 2021. "Small State Security Engagement in Post-Arab Spring MENA: The Case of the United Arab Emirates." *Asian Affairs* 52 (2): 412–25. <https://doi.org/10.1080/03068374.2021.1916248>
- Krieg, Andreas. 2023. "Security Assistance to Surrogates – How the UAE Secures Its Regional Objectives." *Mediterranean Politics* 29 (4): 454–77. <https://doi.org/10.1080/13629395.2023.2183659>



- Kabandula, Abigail, and Federico Donelli. 2024. “Drivers of Influence of Saudi Arabia and the United Arab Emirates in East Africa: Evidence from Sudan.” *South African Journal of International Affairs* 31 (4): 389–409. <https://doi.org/10.1080/10220461.2025.2457061>
-

Part 4: Cases

14. Iraq

Monday, 30 November 2026, 11:00–13:00

Group: TBA (paper due date **27 November 2026**)

- Costantini, Irene, and Dylan O’Driscoll. 2022. “Twenty Years of Externally Promoted Security Assistance in Iraq: Changing Approaches and Their Limits.” *International Peacekeeping* 30 (5): 562–84. <https://doi.org/10.1080/13533312.2022.2149501>
- Jansen, Alies. 2024. “Understanding Security Force Assistance: A Matter of Control?” *Defense & Security Analysis* 40 (1): 80–96. <https://doi.org/10.1080/14751798.2024.2295102>
- Clausen, Maria-Louise. 2025. “Vicarious Impunity: Othering in Security Force Assistance in Iraq.” *Middle East Critique*, published online September 2025. <https://doi.org/10.1080/19436149.2025.2546163>

15. Mali and the Sahel

Tuesday, 1 December 2026, 11:00–13:00

Group: TBA (paper due date **27 November 2026**)

- Marsh, Nicholas, and Øystein H. Rolandsen. 2021. “Fragmented We Fall: Security Sector Cohesion and the Impact of Foreign Security Force Assistance in Mali.” *Journal of Intervention and Statebuilding* 15 (5): 614–629. <https://doi.org/10.1080/17502977.2021.1988226>
- Gazeley, Joe. 2022. “The Strong ‘Weak State’: French Statebuilding and Military Rule in Mali.” *Journal of Intervention and Statebuilding* 16 (3): 269–286. <https://doi.org/10.1080/17502977.2022.2030627>
- Saidou, Abdoul Karim, and Siriki Bagayoko. 2025. “From Euphoria to Disenchantment: Temporality and the Changing Local Perceptions of International Interventions in Mali.” *Journal of Intervention and Statebuilding* 20 (1): 27–49. <https://doi.org/10.1080/17502977.2025.2564518>



- Knubel, Roman. 2026. “From Paris to Moscow: Burkina Faso’s Strategic Realignment and the Rise of the Alliance of the Sahel States.” *Comparative Strategy*, published online 24 June 2026. <https://doi.org/10.1080/01495933.2026.2667274>

16. Ukraine

Monday, 7 December 2026, 11:00–13:00

Group: TBA (paper due date **4 December 2026**)

- Lanoszka, Alexander, and Jordan Becker. 2023. “The Art of Partial Commitment: The Politics of Military Assistance to Ukraine.” *Post-Soviet Affairs* 39 (3): 173–94. <https://doi.org/10.1080/1060586X.2022.2162758>
- Marsh, Nicholas. 2023. “Responding to Needs: Military Aid to Ukraine during the First Year after the 2022 Russian Invasion.” *European Security* 32 (3): 346–70. <https://doi.org/10.1080/14751798.2023.2235121>
- van den Boom, Lotte, and Zbigniew Truchlewski. 2026. “Why Does European Aid to Ukraine Vary? A Nested Analysis of Domestic and International Drivers.” *European Security*, published online 12 March 2026. <https://doi.org/10.1080/09662839.2026.2628915>
- Stewart, Ruben. 2026. “A European Way of War Without the United States.” *Survival* 68 (3): 7–34. <https://doi.org/10.1080/00396338.2026.2678691>

17. Syria

Tuesday, 8 December 2026, 11:00–13:00

Group: TBA (paper due date **4 December 2026**)

- Hall, Natasha. 2025. “With the Fall of Assad, Can Syria Rise?” *Survival* 67 (1): 45–54. <https://doi.org/10.1080/00396338.2025.2459015>
- Kevci, Perisan, and Marco Nilsson. 2026. “Identity and Military Threats in Rojava: The Kurdish Dual Security Dilemma vis-à-vis ISIS, Turkey and Post-Assad Damascus.” *Ethnopolitics*, published online 9 July 2026, 1–20. <https://doi.org/10.1080/17449057.2026.2691459>
- Lefèvre, Raphaël. 2026. “The Radicals’ Dilemma After Civil Wars: Evidence from Syria.” *Survival* 68 (2): 143–160. <https://doi.org/10.1080/00396338.2026.2647644>



18. Conclusion: First, Do No Harm

Monday, 14 December 2026, 14:00–16:00

- Poponete, Valentin, and Nadia Molenaers. 2026. “Fixing the Wrong Failures? Why Security Sector Reform Fails Without Sound Theories of Change.” *Journal of Intervention and Statebuilding*, published online 24 February 2026, 1–20. <https://doi.org/10.1080/17502977.2025.2604472>